

Why free public transport is a terrible idea

Australia's urban sprawl makes mass transit extraordinarily expensive, and the fare experiments in Victoria, Tasmania and Queensland aren't helping.



Once you make something free, it's hard to start charging. And should we charge for public transport? We might not like what we get if we don't. **Kate Geraghty**

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Whether as a response to the oil crisis or just sheer political expediency, Australia has recently embarked on a populist experiment in mass transit.

In Victoria, public transport is free for the second month running, and will be half-price for the rest of the year. Tasmania's buses and

ferries are free until July. Both states have tied their concessions to the fuel crisis.

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